

BURROWING DEEP
The under construction Sela tunnel near Tawang, Arunachal Pradesh, situated at an altitude of 13,000 feet

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Years before tension along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in Ladakh spiralled into a crisis in April 2020, leading to a protracted face-off between the Indian Army and the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China, it was widely acknowledged that the Chinese were building infrastructure at a fast pace to enable men and materiel to be deployed on border areas in the shortest possible time. Indian reaction to Chinese activity on the LAC as well as along the McMahon Line in the Northeast was slow, but picked up pace after 2014, as the NDA government took multiple measures to improve infrastructure. Thus, from 2008 to 2014, 7,270 metres of bridges were built, while 14,450 metres were completed between 2014 and 2020. Similarly, between 2008 and 2014, 3,610 km of border roads were constructed, while the corresponding figure for 2014 to 2020 was 4,764 km. The Indian military believes that improved connectivity to forward areas of the LAC has allowed Indian army patrols to be more thorough, and is directly responsible for frequent skirmishes with the PLA in recent years. "Road construction on the Indian side of the LAC always triggers crises, because of accessibility to Indian patrols. And it always annoys the Chinese military," says former Northern Army commander Lt Gen (retd) D.S. Hooda. Indeed, in May 2020, one apparent reason for the PLA's sudden hostility was India's scaling up of the 255-km high-altitude Darbuk-Shyok-Daulat Beg Oldi (DS-DBO) road, that connects Leh to the Karakoram pass—a sensitive matter for China. With the tocsin of the stand-off still ringing, infrastructure construction on the border with China has received a fresh impetus. Having learnt bitter lessons from the past, the military's emphasis is now on building roads, habitat, bridges, helipads and airstrips to match the Chinese. China, too, is not letting up on further sharpening their own advanced preparedness.

On November 12, two days before Prime Minister Narendra Modi left for Indonesia to attend the G20 summit, New Delhi issued a gazette notification for the construction of the 1,800 km-long Frontier Highway in Arunachal Pradesh. Named National Highway 913, it will follow the McMahon Line—the India-China border in the Northeast disputed by the latter—and will connect the China-Bhutan-India border tri-junction to Vijaynagar via Tawang, Upper Subansari, Siang, Dibang Valley and Kibithu. The government said the highway will safeguard the border, control migration from border areas and improve the tourism infrastructure. The cost is estimated at Rs 27,349 crore and it is expected to take three years to complete. Militarily, it is intended to neutralise China's aggressive posturing in the area and give an unprecedented advantage to the Indian Army in terms of response time, accessibility, logistics and reach. Furthermore, the Frontier Highway connects all the river valleys and enables army units to easily move from one valley to another.

Another road, also under construction, will provide alternative connectivity to western Ladakh and the Zanskar Valley from the Manali axis in Himachal Pradesh. Two-thirds of the work on the 298 km-long double-lane road has been completed. The 4.1 km twin-tube, all-weather Shinkun La tunnel, also on the Himachal Pradesh-Ladakh route, is on track after a green signal from the ministry of defence. The strategically important DS-DBO road, that provides access to high-altitude airfields and military posts, is also getting over 35 'Class -70' upgraded bridges. These are permanent, extra-wide bailey bridges that can bear a load of 70 tonnes—T90 tanks and infantry combat vehicles, for example—and are expected to be completed by 2023. Recently, the army successfully conducted trials for constructing assault bridges—high-mobility vehicle-